



2026 **MAYOR'S INNOVATION CHALLENGE PITCH COMPETITION**

PARTICIPANT'S INFORMATION PACKAGE

Friday, March 20, 2026
9 a.m. to 1 :30 p.m.
Kingston City Hall, 216 Ontario St.



MAYOR'S INNOVATION CHALLENGE
CITY OF KINGSTON

Dear participants,

Congratulations on making it to the 2026 Mayor's Innovation Challenge Pitch Competition. This is a significant achievement, and we are thrilled to see your innovative ideas and creative solutions receive the recognition they deserve.

After evaluating all the submissions, we've selected the top eight teams to compete. This year's finalists have proposed a diverse range of ideas aimed at improving the lives of residents and enhancing municipal services.

The competition will kick off on Friday, March 20 at 9 a.m. in the Council Chambers at City Hall. **Please arrive by no later than 8:45 a.m.** so we can get you settled. You can use the main front door on Ontario Street and make your way to the second floor. Each pitch will last **up to 8 minutes for the presentation and 5 minutes for Q&A.** You are welcome to use your submission video as part of your pitch if you wish (leaving you the remaining time for a presentation). PowerPoints and other visuals are welcome and should be emailed ahead of time to mic@cityofkingston.ca. All **presentation materials are due by 4:00 p.m. on Tuesday, March 17.** Please submit your presentation as a PowerPoint file and embed all videos, demos, or other media directly in the deck. Wi-Fi at City Hall can be unreliable, so this will help ensure your presentation runs smoothly when we download it in advance.

There are two prizes up for grabs:

- 1. The Dunin-Deshpande Innovation Centre Prize:** This winner will gain admission to the Queen's Founders and Innovators Initiative (QFII) program, a transformative, part-time program that helps aspiring innovators and entrepreneurs take their early-stage startups to the next level. Beginning in April, Winners will receive world-class entrepreneurship training, mentorship from industry professionals, and the opportunity to unlock up to \$4,000 in seed funding, and the opportunity to compete for up to \$30,000 in DDQIC's Regional Pitch Competition.
- 2. The Public Sector Innovation Prize:** This winner will receive a \$10,000 cash prize sponsored by Bell Canada, to advance their idea, as well as admission to the Summer Company Program. This program offers resources, mentorship, and hands-on business mentoring from local business leaders.

Please note the event will be livestreamed on YouTube and some members of the media might attend for the winners announcement at the end of the event. For more information about this year's Mayor's Innovation Challenge, please visit [Getinvolved.cityofkingston.ca/mayors-innovation-challenge-2026](https://getinvolved.cityofkingston.ca/mayors-innovation-challenge-2026)

Thank you again for your participation and we are looking forward to having you at City Hall!

Sincerely,
The MIC Team



SPONSORS AND PARTNERS

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Welcome and Introductions • MC Welcomes judges, students, viewers and those joining via livestream. • MC turns over to the mayor to kick-off the event • MC introduces the judges • MC welcomes sponsors and partners to say a few words • MC goes over prizes and flow of events	9-9:30 a.m.
Team 1 pitch followed by Q&A	9:30-9:45 a.m.
Team 2 pitch followed by Q&A	9:45-10:00 a.m.
Team 3 pitch followed by Q&A	10:00-10:15 a.m.
Team 4 pitch followed by Q&A	10:15-10:30 a.m.
Break	10:30-10:45 a.m.
Team 5 pitch followed by Q&A	10:45-11:00 a.m.
Team 6 pitch followed by Q&A	11:00-11:15 a.m.
Team 7 pitch followed by Q&A	11:15-11:30 a.m.
Team 7 pitch followed by Q&A	11:30-11:45 a.m.
Team 8 pitch followed by Q&A	11:45-12:00 p.m.
Lunch & judges deliberation	12 - 1 p.m.
Winners announcement/ Event conclusion	1 - 1:30 p.m.

MEET OUR JUDGES



Bryan Paterson, Mayor - City of Kingston

Bryan was first elected as the 96th Mayor of the City of Kingston in 2014. He was re-elected in 2018, and on Oct. 24, 2022, he was re-elected for a third term. He first ran for City Council in 2010. Bryan moved to Kingston in 2000 to attend Queen's University as a graduate student and in 2006, after obtaining his Master and PhD in Economics at Queen's, he joined the economics faculty at Canada's Royal Military College in Kingston where he continues to work as an Assistant Professor. As Mayor, Bryan's vision is to establish Kingston as an innovative and forward-thinking city. This vision aims to harness the incredible assets we have as a community and build a culture of collaboration to make Kingston a leader among cities. The MIC is a project Bryan is very passionate about and he is looking forward to being a judge during the 9th edition of the challenge.

Bob McDonald, Client Executive - Bell Canada

Bob McDonald is a senior professional with over 25 years of experience in Information Technology and telecommunications. He possesses extensive expertise in cybersecurity, cloud computing, and enterprise architecture. Bob is adept at translating complex technical concepts into business solutions, serving as a trusted advisor to public sector customers.

He has a strong track record in developing and executing sales strategies for public sector clients, leveraging deep market insights, understanding emerging technology trends, and navigating stringent compliance requirements. His experience includes overseeing client engagements, delivering compelling proposals, and building executive-level relationships within government entities.



Jim McLellan, Academic Director and co-founder of DDQIC

Jim McLellan is the Academic Director and a co-founder of the Dunin-Deshpande Queen's Innovation Centre which champions innovation and entrepreneurship across all programs of study at Queen's University, in the Kingston region, and beyond. Jim helped develop the flagship summer innovation program at Queen's, and has helped design, implement, and teach programs and courses related to innovation and entrepreneurship in the Faculty of Engineering and Applied Science, the Smith School of Business, and the Faculty of Arts and Science. He is particularly interested in the use of systems and design thinking for social and business innovation and has been actively involved in the Community Opportunities Lab and Health Innovation YGK initiatives with the City of Kingston and regional partners. Jim is a professor of Chemical Engineering and served as Head of Chemical Engineering for ten years and is cross-appointed to Mathematics & Statistics, and the Dan School of Drama and Music. Jim is the Queen's Lead for the national Mitacs/Simon Fraser University Invention to Innovation (i2I) program and is Activity Co-Lead with the Genome Canada-funded Open Plastics research program for plastics circularity.



Ben McIlquham Investment Manager, Life Sciences & Health Innovation

Ben is a senior economic development leader specializing in health and life sciences for Kingston Economic Development. With 20 years of experience across government, industry, non-profits, and business development, he has built a strong track record in investment attraction, ecosystem development, and securing strategic funding to accelerate sector growth. Ben leads initiatives that position Kingston as a competitive destination for health and life sciences companies to establish, scale, and commercialize. He has successfully secured funding to strengthen the region's innovation infrastructure and support company expansion, helping to advance Kingston's role as a leading life sciences hub. He serves on the Boards of Directors for Ontario East Economic Development and Kingston Health Sciences Centre (KHSC), contributing to regional economic strategy and healthcare system governance. Ben also plays a leadership role in advancing cross-border collaboration through the Kingston Syracuse Pathway, supporting companies in expanding into new markets. Born in Kingston and a graduate of the University of Western Ontario, Ben brings a strategic, partnership-driven approach to economic development, aligning industry, healthcare, academic, and government stakeholders to drive long-term growth and competitiveness.



Morgan Lehtinen, Executive Director RXN HUB

Driven by Morgan's experience as a PhD founder out of Queen's University, she has dedicated her career to fixing the fragmented commercialization path for chemistry-based technologies. As Executive Director of RXN HUB, Morgan leads a national coalition of start-up supporters to provide first-of-its-kind, near-net-zero infrastructure designed to move cleantech ventures from the lab bench to industrial scale. Expanding this impact to a strategic level, she serves as the Mitacs i2I National Advisory Lead for Cleantech, acting as a prominent voice for the Canadian ecosystem to drive sustainable innovation on a national scale. Passionate about collaboration and innovation, Morgan is an avid speaker, mentor, and builder of initiatives to support under-represented groups in STEM and entrepreneurship. The impact of her work has been recognized through a variety of awards including Corporate Knights' Top 30 Under 30 Sustainability Leaders, Canada's Most Powerful Women: Top 100, and the Agnes Benedickson Tricolour Award—the highest tribute paid to a student for distinguished service at Queen's University.



Emil Mathew, Queen's student, CEO and Co-Founder of Perceivable

Emil Mathew is completing a Bachelor's degree in Mechatronics and Robotics Engineering at Queen's University, expecting to graduate in April 2026. In 2025, Emil and his team won the Mayor's Innovation Challenge with an initiative originally named Handfluence. Following this, he completed the Dunin-Deshpande Queen's Innovation Centre (DDQIC) QFII program to iterate the concept. This work evolved into Perceivable Design Studios Inc., an adaptive tech development startup co-founded by Emil. The company creates tools for physical access, cognitive support, and inclusive communication in both digital and physical spaces. Emil is currently collaborating with the deaf community to bridge communication gaps and deliver unified accessibility solutions. His professional focus is driven by the conviction that education must be applied to generate tangible impact.



ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

Arrival and presentations:

Please arrive by no later than 8:45 a.m. You can use the main doors of City Hall (on Ontario Street) and make your way to the second floor (Memorial Hall). There will be staff to assist you with check-in.

The event will start at 9 a.m. Each team will have eight minutes allocated for their pitch, followed by a five-minute Q&A. There will be a staff member present to let you know when you have two minutes left and when you should conclude (30 seconds left).

Ahead of your pitch:

PowerPoints and other visuals are welcome and should be emailed ahead of time to mic@cityofkingston.ca. All presentation materials are due by 4:00 p.m. on Tuesday, March 17. Please submit your presentation as a PowerPoint file and embed all videos, demos, or other media directly in the deck. Wi-Fi at City Hall can be unreliable, so this will help ensure your presentation runs smoothly when we download it in advance.

If you are joining us for a practice round, we will see you on Monday, March 16. If not, we will see you on pitch day, March 20!

If you have any questions ahead of your pitch, please do not hesitate to reach out to mic@CityofKingston.ca

See you soon and wishing you all the best as you prepare for your pitch!